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read this - it's
in the
conference
program

Description (changed by the conference people) : Using video as a medium to raise awareness: the tutor/mentor connection. How can you use video as a medium to raise awareness about human rights? This workshop will explore the methods of Cabrini Connections, a non-profit organization in Chicago that works with youth to document their experiences through video.

T/MC :

What is tutoring? What is mentoring?

Just as you all came up with different definitions there are different needs in different parts of most cities. There are also different solutions. But what doesn't differ is the fact that there are many poverty areas in Chicago (and most cities), with many poorly performing and under-funded schools. In these neighborhoods there is a need for more afterschool youth programs that offer comprehensive and long term forms of tutoring & mentoring. There is a need for schools and afterschool programs to be more successful in helping the kids they serve to grow up, get jobs, and be able to take care of their families.

That is the goal of the T/MC.

- 4 points overhead (explain a bit)

Let me diverge for a moment ^{and} put this into context for you. Why are we talking about tutoring & mentoring? This conference is about juvenile justice, right? So how does tutoring & mentoring fit into all this? By creating more programs in the afterschool, 3 - 8 PM time slot, by creating more opportunities for our kids to stay off the streets, we can start to prevent the issue of juvenile justice altogether. By creating situations or places where they can not get into trouble, if we can avoid the actions that have negative consequences, then we're able to focus on the potential of the future and how we can help shape it.

When the T/MC was formed, there was no concentrated effort to reach out to every tutor/mentor program in the city with a "how can I help you succeed message. There was no way to look at program distribution on a map of the city and see neighborhoods where there were no programs.

There was no attempt to look for "best practices" with a vision of sharing that information so every program could be a best practice. And there was little public

Tutor/Mentor Connection

This doc is draft of a conference presentation talking about T/MC.
It's also draft of funding request for Innervisions Youth Production (IYP) video program.

Prepared by Steve Roussos 1999

leadership, or on going marketing to keep this issue in the public eye in-between the tragedies of kids killing kids, such as the Dantrell Davis case, which gave this issue national attention for a short period of time.

- what every program needs overheads (7 or 8 of them, run through quickly)
- summary overhead
- define best practice

T/MC was established to fill these voids, and for six years it has been building a year round schedule of events and actions which bring more visibility, volunteers, ideas, training and dollars to every tutor/mentor program in the city.

Engaging students in creating videos is one part of that strategy. Empowering students to tell the story, makes that strategy unique. This directly relates to Innervision Youth Productions, a creative program at Cabrini Connections, both which are groups we will talk about in a bit.

The tutor/mentor connection is all about kids. It's about afterschool programs where kids can connect with adults, learn skills, find support and be safe. A study, conducted in 1997 by the T/MC, human capital research and the associated colleges of illinois found that the 272 youth services in chicago reach less than 6% of chicago's school age population. Why is this? Well, one reason is that people feel they don't have access to the knowledge about these programs. And that's one thing that the T/MC strives to do.

- how many programs are needed overhead

Since it was founded in 1993 by Cabrini Connections, T/MC has developed a comprehensive set of actions. Here are some of its accomplishments:

One, it has created a directory of all afterschool programs in Chicago, which it distributes to more than 4000 companies, churches, schools and volunteers each year, so volunteers, donors, business partners and students alike can find existing programs.

Two, it organizes 2 leadership conferences a year, one in the fall and one in the spring. The two 1998 conferences were each attended by more than 260 people from throughout the midwest.

Three, it holds an annual citywide volunteer recruitment campaign. Last year more than 85 youth agencies recruited volunteers at 20 different sites in Chicago, Evanston, Peoria and Quincy on the same weekend.

Four, T/MC has a tutor/mentor week each year, which highlights the efforts of organizations and individuals and raises operating dollars to fund one-on-one tutor/mentor programs.

And finally, but probably most importantly, T/MC strives to have an on-going discussion of how to make every tutor/mentor program in America the best it can be, through sharing resources and knowledge. The logic is this : if we combine the best research with input from those with the most experience and who are the most committed, we can only produce the most successful ideas to share with everyone. And if those ideas don't work out in practice, then what we have created is a network of information upon which we can fall back, and start the process over again.

It's all about communication. It's all about awareness.



Talk about Cabrini Connections (use overheads)

- as an organization
- as part of T/MC
- your own experiences

IYP was born out of a unique set of needs and opportunities.

The needs:

- * To build visibility for tutor/mentor programs during the feb/march period;
- * To find ways to put this story on video, and to rebroadcast it on public tv;
- * To find ways to build revenue for Cabrini Connections at a time of the year when it was usually broke,
- * and to find ways to engage kids more creatively in the learning process at Its own kids' connection program.

The history:

In July 1995 a volunteer said to Dan Bassill, "I have a friend who will donate \$2000 for video equipment. What will you do with it?" Bassill and Sara Caldwell, a video producer, expanded on an existing concept of kids writing and doing desktop production on a kids magazine, to say, with the equipment, kids could be writing, editing and producing their own videos.

Taking the \$2000, Caldwell went to an auction and purchased a variety of used equipment. She also placed an ad in Screen Magazine for volunteers to help with this.

Once the equipment was at Cabrini Connections, there still was not anyone who knew how to use it. Danny Sherrod, a 10th grade student at that time, had taken a columbia college summer course and was familiar with the equipment. While showing Dan Bassill how to use it, the inspiration hit Bassill that students could build ~~films~~^{videos} that would tell the tutor/mentor story (based on what was already happening at Cabrini Connections each week). A film festival in february would give a "completion date" for an annual cycle of films, and do so at a time the program needed an event to raise visibility and raise dollars.

Bassil and Sherrod brainstormed the idea and recorded their vision on tape in one afternoon.

As luck would have it, Carrie Clifford responded to the screen magazine ad shortly after that and when Bassill outlined the vision to Clifford, she jumped at the idea of making it a reality. She recruited her friend Gloria Hall Brewster and within a year, a first film festival was offered, and Innervision Youth Productions was formed.

We've evolved this into 3 parts of our mission for IYP :

1. To tell the story of T/MC
2. Learning skills/hobbies to take to school, careers & beyond
3. Creative arts training to compliment academics

Our mission is to provide an environment in which at-risk students are able to succeed creatively through the medium of video. By creating visual works, the students not only learn the skills necessary to produce videos, but also learn how to problem solve and work together as a team. Our goal is to help students gain knowledge that they can take out into the world.

Another goal of the program, however, is to eventually have a self-sufficient program where the kids are not only making movies for the festival, but are expanding their technical knowledge through a fully equipped editing suite. As technology changes and becomes digital, it would be great if the kids could run all of the equipment themselves, giving them that many more skills to become a contributing member of society. We are trying to give these kids that chance. Through training and building of resources, one goal is to eventually be able to 'hire' the kids in the program to create video/commercial/film works of their own that they can pitch and get paid for.

How the program runs :

Students begin preparing for the annual video festival each September when they are divided into groups and assigned volunteers. Each group works on one video for the following 6 months, learning all aspects of video production. In addition, the volunteers are split into groups based on their area of expertise, and together they present one workshop to the rest of the group. Every year, we try to have a writing workshop, an equipment workshop and a production workshop. The students apply what they learn in each of these workshops to their on-going video project. Volunteer editors edit the pieces with input from the students, giving the students a chance to see the whole process from start to finish. This year, 10 volunteers taught 26 students how to use a variety of sound and video equipment to produce the five videos you will see tonight. These videos illustrate the immense talent and dedication of both the students and the volunteers. While the students work for 6 months on original screenplays, the program is a year-round

effort led by volunteers. All of their hard work culminates in a video festival in March, which is open to the public.

As mentioned above, the program started 2 years ago, with 2 volunteers, 8 students and a video camera. This group worked on 5 videos with donated equipment, and sparked so much interest in the community, that over 170 people attended the first video festival. One of the pieces, 'The Real Cabrini', a documentary on life in Cabrini Green, went on to win first place in the documentary category of the 2nd Annual Chicago Youth Film & Video Festival. Buoyed by the success of the first year, last year 10 volunteers and sixteen students returned to make the 2nd year even better. Not only did we have the support of the local community, but the Chicago media picked up our story with enthusiasm, and covered the festival with extensive coverage. And once again, one of our videos 'The Adopted One', a mock horror story spoof, went on to win first place at the 3rd Annual Chicago Youth Film & Video Festival in the narrative category. In addition, we were invited to screen all of the students' works at the Chicago Alt.Film Festival, which showed us that people want to know about and support the dreams of urban youth.

Already what makes our program unique is that we are teaching these youth to make films & videos with a 'call to action', videos that will tell viewers about youth agencies like Cabrini Connections, as well as drawing in more volunteers and partners so more of Chicago's kids can participate in programs like this. Our students videos have been screened at the Chicago Youth Film & Video Festival as well as the Chicago.Alt Film Festival.

As students learn to produce better and better videos, we will help them focus more and more on telling a story that draws a response, be it volunteers, donors and leaders for tutor/mentor programs, or better health care for their families and neighborhoods.

Video is a powerful communications tool. If kids learn to use it, and to think, work as teams, write powerful, call to action work, and put it in front of the public in a variety of forums, our process will have prepared a small cadre of new leaders for the 21st century.

If we are successful of showing that video groups like IYP can, and should be part of neighborhood programs throughout Chicago and other cities, and that each year, each

program can get better by sharing ideas and competing with each other to be the best, we can create an army of leaders.

That is the vision of the T/MC and the role IYP plays in this vision.

- play video

- ~~do~~ questions?